

Prehistoric India & the Indus Valley Civilisation

The story of humanity's earliest footprints on Indian soil

SSC CGL | Bank PO | RRB | UPSC Prelims

3000 BCE – 300 BCE

3000

BCE Harappan start

5+

major site clusters

~1500

BCE decline date

4

decline theories

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Chapter 1 — The Dawn of Humanity in India

Long before the rivers Indus and Saraswati gave birth to cities, long before the first city wall was raised or the first grain was stored, human beings were already walking the Indian subcontinent. Their story begins not with writing or trade, but with a single sharp stone — a tool chipped from rock that let one species survive, hunt, and eventually *think*.

India's prehistoric record stretches back an astonishing **~2 million years** to the Lower Palaeolithic era. The evidence comes not from text but from stone tools, ash layers, animal bones, and painted rock shelters — silent testimonies to lives lived before history had a voice.

Bhimbetka (Madhya Pradesh) preserves rock shelters occupied continuously from 100,000 BCE to the medieval era — the longest continuous human habitation site in India.

Chapter 2 — Stone Age: Three Phases India Must Know

Historians divide prehistoric India into three broad phases based on the tools people used and the way they organised their lives. Understanding these phases is not just academic — **SSC and RRB exams regularly test tool types, key sites, and food sources.**

Phase	Time Period	Tools & Lifestyle	Key Sites
Palaeolithic (Old Stone Age)	500,000 – 10,000 BCE	Crude core tools, hand axes, flakes. Hunter-gatherers, cave dwellers. Fire discovered.	Bhimbetka (MP), Hunsgi (Karnataka), Belan Valley (UP)
Mesolithic (Middle Stone Age)	10,000 – 6,000 BCE	Microliths (tiny blades). Semi-nomadic, began animal domestication, rock art flourishes.	Adamgarh (MP), Sarai Nahar Rai (UP), Langhnaj (Gujarat)
Neolithic (New Stone Age)	6,000 – 1,000 BCE	Polished stone tools. Settled farming, pottery (hand-made), weaving, village life emerges.	Mehrgarh (Balochistan) ← earliest!, Burzahom (Kashmir), Chirand (Bihar)
Chalcolithic (Copper-Stone Age)	3,500 – 1,500 BCE	First use of copper alongside stone. Black-and-red pottery. Trade with Harappans.	Jorwe (Maharashtra), Ahar (Rajasthan), Kayatha (MP)

Mehrgarh is the single most important Neolithic site in Indian prehistory. Located in present-day Balochistan, Pakistan, it dates to ~7000 BCE and shows the earliest evidence of wheat/barley cultivation and cattle herding in South Asia — making it the *seedbed* of the Indus Valley Civilisation that would bloom 3,500 years later.

Chapter 3 — The Harappan World Is Born (3300 – 2600 BCE)

Around 3300 BCE, something remarkable happened along the banks of the Indus river system. The small farming villages of the Chalcolithic era began to grow — not randomly, but with **deliberate intent**. Streets were laid at right angles. Drains were built underground. Granaries were constructed to feed thousands. The world's first *planned* urban civilisation had arrived.

Historians divide the Harappan story into three phases. Each tells a part of the remarkable arc from agricultural village to metropolis — and back to silence.

Phase	Period	What Happened
Early Harappan	3300–2600 BCE	Village-to-town transition. Proto-writing appears. Regional cultures merge.
Mature Harappan	2600–1900 BCE	Peak phase. Great cities built. Standardised weights, script, bricks. Trade with Mesopotamia.

Late Harappan	1900–1300 BCE	Decline begins. Cities shrink, population disperses eastward. Quality of artifacts falls.
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*The Harappan script — with ~400-600 symbols — has NEVER been deciphered.
It is written right-to-left and appears on seals, pottery and tablets.
Exam favourite: 'Harappan script is undeciphered' is a direct MCQ answer.*

Chapter 4 — Life Inside a Harappan City

Step inside Mohenjo-Daro at its peak — around 2500 BCE. You walk down a straight, wide street, flanked by brick houses with no windows facing outward (for privacy and security). Beneath your feet, covered drains carry waste water to soak pits outside the city. The smell of baked bread drifts from a nearby granary. This is not primitive — this is sophisticated urban planning that Europe would not match for another 3,000 years.

Urban Feature	Detail	Significance
Grid street plan	Roads intersecting at right angles; main roads ~10m wide	World's first town planning concept
Drainage system	Covered underground drains connecting all houses to main sewers	No parallel in ancient world — evidence of civic authority
Citadel + Lower Town	Two-part layout: raised citadel (public/elite) + lower residential town	Suggests a class/administrative hierarchy
Great Bath (Mohenjo-Daro)	12m x 7m brick pool, waterproofed with bitumen, changing rooms around it	Likely for ritual purification — ancestor of temple tanks
Granaries	Large brick structures with ventilation ducts; found at Harappa & Mohenjo-Daro	Evidence of centralised food storage and state control
Standardised bricks	Ratio 1:2:4 (height:width:length) used uniformly across all sites	Proves a central authority maintaining standards across 1.5M sq km
Weights & measures	Cubical stone weights in binary progression (1,2,4,8,16...)	Standardised trade — no parallel in contemporary civilisations
No temples found	Absence of monumental temples unlike Mesopotamia and Egypt	Suggests secular governance or domestic worship — still debated

Chapter 5 — The Great Sites: A Geographic Tour

The Indus Valley Civilisation was not just two cities. At its peak, it covered **~1.5 million sq km** — larger than ancient Egypt and Mesopotamia combined. Over **2,000 settlements** have been identified. The sites below are the ones that appear in government exam questions year after year. Learn each with its state, river, and unique feature.

Site	Present-Day Location	River	Unique Discovery / Claim to Fame
Harappa	<i>Punjab, Pakistan</i>	Ravi	First site discovered (1921); gave the civilisation its name; evidence of 6 granaries in two rows
Mohenjo-Daro ('Mound of the Dead')	<i>Sindh, Pakistan</i>	Indus	Largest city; Great Bath; 'Dancing Girl' bronze; 'Priest-King' steatite statue; college/assembly hall
Lothal	<i>Gujarat, India</i>	Bhogavo (Sabarmati tributary)	World's first dockyard (tidal lock design); evidence of bead-making factory; fire altars; Persian Gulf trade
Dholavira	<i>Rann of Kutch, Gujarat, India</i>	Mansar & Manhar (seasonal)	Largest site in India; 3-part layout (unique); inscription board (10 large signs); UNESCO World Heritage Site (2021)
Kalibangan	<i>Rajasthan, India</i>	Ghaggar (ancient Saraswati)	Earliest ploughed field in the world (pre-Harappan); fire altars on citadel; both pre-Harappan and mature phases found
Banawali	<i>Haryana, India</i>	Ghaggar	Oval-shaped settlement; best preserved ploughed field; lapis lazuli beads; toy plough found
Rakhigarhi	<i>Haryana, India</i>	Ghaggar-Hakra	Largest Harappan site overall (larger than Mohenjo-Daro); DNA study (2019) confirms indigenous origin of Harappans
Surkotada	<i>Gujarat, India</i>	Near Rann of Kutch	Earliest evidence of horse bones in South Asia (debated); fortified town with unique layout
Chanhudaro	<i>Sindh, Pakistan</i>	Indus	Bead and shell bangle workshops; inkpot found; no citadel (only Harappan city without one)

Memory trick for sites in India: 'L-D-K-B-R' → Lothal, Dholavira, Kalibangan, Banawali, Rakhigarhi. Sites in Pakistan: Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro, Chanhudaro.

Chapter 6 — Trade, Economy & Culture

The Harappans were not just builders — they were one of the ancient world's great *trading civilisations*. Their merchant ships docked at Mesopotamian ports; their carnelian beads have been found in royal Sumerian graves. Understanding their economy reveals a sophisticated, interconnected world.

Domain	Key Facts
Crops	Wheat, barley (main crops). Also: cotton (first in the world!), sesame, mustard, peas, dates

Animals	Cattle, buffalo, sheep, goat, elephant, humped bull (sacred). Dog and cat as pets.
Crafts & Industry	Bead-making (carnelian, lapis lazuli, gold), shell bangles, bronze casting, pottery (wheel-made, black on red), weaving, boat-building (Lothal)
External Trade	Trade with Mesopotamia ('Meluha' in Sumerian texts), Oman, Bahrain (Dilmun). Export: cotton, beads, ivory. Import: tin, silver, lapis lazuli
Currency / Commerce	No coins found. Trade via barter using standardised stone weights. Seals (steatite) used as merchant ID — like a business card
Religion & Culture	Mother Goddess worship (many terracotta figurines). Pashupati seal (proto-Shiva). Tree worship, unicorn-like animal on seals. No grand temples — domestic shrines likely
Famous Artifacts	Dancing Girl (bronze, Mohenjo-Daro) Priest-King (steatite, Mohenjo-Daro) Pashupati Seal Unicorn Seal Toy carts Dice Inkpot (Chanhudaro)

Chapter 7 — The Mysterious Collapse (~1900 – 1300 BCE)

And then — silence. Between 1900 and 1300 BCE, the great Harappan cities were abandoned. The granaries emptied. The streets fell quiet. The standardised brick sizes were forgotten. One of history's greatest civilisations simply... stopped. **Why?** This question has haunted archaeologists for a century, and the answer is still debated. Every major government exam has tested these theories.

Theory	Proposed By	Evidence For	Evidence Against / Weakness
Aryan Invasion Theory	<i>Mortimer Wheeler (1940s)</i>	Skeletons found in streets of Mohenjo-Daro; 'Indra stands accused' (Wheeler's words)	Skeletons are post-decline (not battle-killed). No Aryan weapons/camps found at sites. DNA evidence (Rakhigarhi 2019) refutes mass migration.
Climate Change / Drought Theory	<i>Gwen Robbins Schug, Livi Giosan (2012)</i>	Monsoon weakening ~2000 BCE confirmed by isotope studies; eastward population shift toward Gangetic plains (more rainfall)	Decline was gradual over 600+ years, not sudden. Some cities thrived even as others declined.
River Drying / Saraswati Shift	<i>Multiple geologists; satellite imagery studies</i>	Most sites concentrated along dried Ghaggar-Hakra (ancient Saraswati). River shifted course due to tectonic activity, destroying agriculture.	Saraswati drying was gradual. Urban collapse may have caused migration, not the reverse.
Flood Theory	<i>M.R. Sahnii, R.L. Raikes</i>	Evidence of flood deposits at Mohenjo-Daro (multiple layers of mud); city rebuilt several times over flood plains	Floods alone cannot explain the entire civilisation's decline across 1.5 million sq km.

The consensus today: NO single cause. The decline was likely a 'perfect storm' of climate change + river drying + trade collapse + internal migration.
For exams: know ALL four theories AND their main critic/weakness.

■ EXAM RADAR — Must-Know Facts

- • Harappa was discovered in 1921 by Daya Ram Sahni; Mohenjo-Daro in 1922 by R.D. Banerji.
- • The civilisation is also called 'Bronze Age civilisation' or 'Harappan civilisation'.
- • Cotton was first cultivated in the world by the Harappans.
- • The Great Bath is at Mohenjo-Daro — NOT Harappa. Do not confuse the two.
- • Lothal has the world's first dockyard. Kalibangan has the world's first ploughed field.
- • Dholavira (Gujarat) became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2021 — very exam-relevant.
- • Rakhigarhi (Haryana) is the LARGEST Harappan site by area.
- • Chanhudaro is the only major Harappan city with NO citadel.
- • The Harappan script has NOT been deciphered — this is a direct MCQ answer in many exams.
- • The Dancing Girl is made of BRONZE. The Priest-King is made of STEATITE (soapstone).
- • Mehrgarh (Balochistan) is the earliest Neolithic site — predates Harappa by 4,000 years.
- • Bhimbetka (MP) = rock shelters + cave paintings; NOT an IVC site — a Palaeolithic site.
- • Aryan Invasion Theory was proposed by Mortimer Wheeler — refuted by DNA evidence (2019).
- • Climate/drought theory (Giosan 2012) is currently the most accepted decline explanation.

Quick Revision — 5-Minute Recap Before the Exam

Prehistoric phases	Palaeolithic → Mesolithic → Neolithic → Chalcolithic. Each defined by tool type and lifestyle.
IVC geography	Covers modern Pakistan + NW India. Main river: Indus. Extent: 1.5 million sq km. 2000+ sites.
Three IVC phases	Early (3300 BCE) → Mature (2600 BCE, peak) → Late (1900 BCE, decline).
Urban features	Grid streets, covered drainage, citadel+lower town, Great Bath, standardised bricks (1:2:4), granaries.
Sites in India	Lothal (dockyard), Dholavira (3-part + UNESCO), Kalibangan (ploughed field), Banawali, Rakhigarhi (largest).
Famous artifacts	Dancing Girl (bronze), Priest-King (steatite), Pashupati seal, Unicorn seal — all from Mohenjo-Daro.
Trade	With Mesopotamia. Cotton exported (world first). No coins — barter + stone weights.
Decline	4 theories: Aryan Invasion (Wheeler, now discredited) Climate/Drought (most accepted) River Drying Floods.